

MELISH REVERSES PART OF TESTIMONY

**Now Admits Vice Presidency
of Civil Rights Congress
of New York in 1947**

The Rev. William Howard Melish admitted yesterday, after having "refreshed my memory," that he had been a vice president of the Civil Rights Congress of New York in 1947.

He thus changed testimony given last Thursday under oath at a hearing of the Subversive Activities Control Board. Mr. Melish was an incorporator, has been chairman and is now a director of the National Council for American Soviet Friendship, which is attempting to prevent its listing as a Communist front.

A Distinction As to Scope

Last week the clergyman, who is acting minister of the Holy Trinity Protestant Episcopal Church, Brooklyn, was asked by Oliver J. Butler Jr., special assistant to the United States Attorney General, if he had been a vice president of the Civil Rights Congress, an alleged Communist front, in 1947.

"I have no memory of it," he said then.

Yesterday he told David J. Coddaire, a member of the board who is hearing the case:

"I have refreshed my memory

since the other day, and I was a member of the Civil Rights Congress of New York, not a member of the national body, which I understood I was being asked about."

During his five days of cross-examination by Mr. Butler, Mr. Melish has replied frequently that "I do not remember" or "I have no memory of it" when asked about membership in, sponsorship of or speaking engagements for alleged Communist fronts.

He reiterated several times yesterday, however, a principle that he said he followed by joining organizations.

"Listing by the Attorney General [as a Communist front] is not to me sufficient reason for not participating in organizations without other information," he said at one point.

Fund Denial Repeated

On another activity, Mr. Melish refused to change earlier testimony, in which he denied that he had been a member or supporter of The Daily Worker Fund Campaign in 1945.

Shown a photostatic copy of the Communist party newspaper for March 25, 1945, which listed him as a sponsor and quoted him urging support for the fund, Mr. Melish said he did not remember being a sponsor.

He said that he was testifying to the best of his ability and that he was not pleading a hazy memory to avoid admissions.

"I shall be very happy to attest to anything I have done," he added.

As to whether the Soviet Un-

ion is a totalitarian state or is a dictatorship, the clergyman said those were "emotional labels." He also said the Communist party in this country was using "democratic constitutional processes" to attain its goals.

The hearing will continue at 9:30 A. M. today at the Immigration and Naturalization Service, 70 Columbus Avenue.